

SWITZERLAND AND AUSTRIA

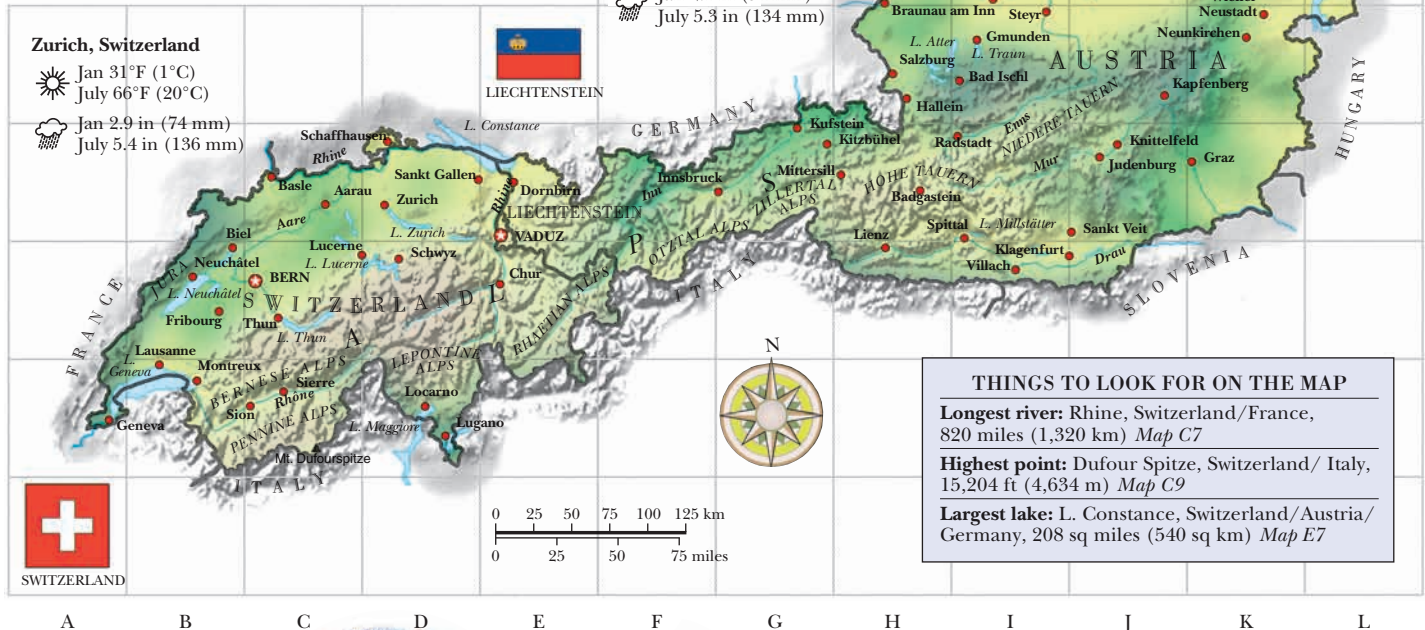
HOME TO EUROPE'S TALLEST MOUNTAINS, the Alps, this region includes Switzerland, Austria, and the tiny state of Liechtenstein. The mountains have shaped the way Switzerland and Austria are organized politically, since communication has been difficult. Each is split up into individual districts with great control over their own affairs.



With no direct access to the sea and few natural resources, both countries have had to maintain good relations with their neighbors and develop specialized industries.

MOUNTAINS AND LAKES

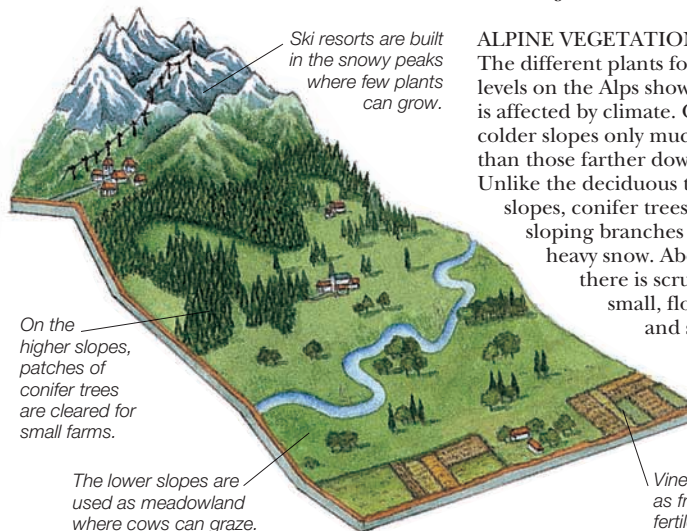
Idyllic scenes of towns and villages next to peaceful lakes are just one of the sights that inspire so many tourists to visit this part of the world. Europe's largest lakes and its highest mountains are found in these two countries.



For centuries, narrow mountain passes have been the main links with surrounding countries.

COMMUNICATIONS

The towering Alps cut through these two countries, forming a massive wall separating northern Europe from the Mediterranean countries farther south. In the past, people had to cross the mountains via steep passes that were often blocked by snow. Today, tunnels and high bridges provide year-round access for road and rail transportation – Swiss engineering firms have become world experts in tunnel construction.



ALPINE VEGETATION

The different plants found at different levels on the Alps show how vegetation is affected by climate. On the upper, colder slopes only much hardier plants than those farther down can survive. Unlike the deciduous trees on the lower slopes, conifer trees have downward sloping branches so they can shed heavy snow. Above the tree line there is scrubland where only small, flowering plants and shrubs can thrive.